

A Massive Vote for India

The large voter turnout and a clean sweep by the Congress is a rebuff to Chinese belligerence and shows the people are solidly behind India



KHANDU HAS WON UNOPPOSED FOR THE THIRD TIME

UB PHOTOS

An enduring feature of politics in Arunachal Pradesh has been horse-trading. No sooner are election results out that legislators switch sides to join the party that has the best chance of coming to power. That will not be necessary any more. The ruling Congress's sweep in the 60-seat Assembly means that, as elsewhere nationally, the state has made its choice clear, voted against the anti-incumbency factor and given a thumbs up to the development programmes of the Congress. And like in many other states, the Opposition is in tatters.

But there is a larger message from the voters that transcends borders. The turnout on October 13 was a stunning 72 per cent, the highest in any state in recent times and five per cent more than the last assembly election in

party. Nine BJP MLAs defected as soon as the Congress assumed power in 2004 as did two from the NCP. A year earlier, a major chunk of Congressmen had left the party to join the BJP, which has had a serious setback this time with its top leader, Kiren Rijiju, defecting to the Congress before the polls. Shortly after the results came in, Rijiju said, "The state Government's signing of agreements for 103 hydropower projects in the last three years and prime minister's Rs 24,000-crore development package announced last year have paid off."

Sources in Itanagar said that people in the state usually vote on "what they see" and don't probe deeper. "In that, the Congress has played a clever game. The signing of MOUs and aggressive campaigning on the prime minister's package plus his visit sealed the Opposition's fate. This is the first step of Arunachal Pradesh coming into the Indian mainstream," they said.

Chief Minister's Dorjee Khandu's first reactions as the results were out was that "the verdict is a slap on the face of those in China who are protesting against the visit of our prime minister as well as the Dalai Lama to the state. We have nothing to do with China". The huge turnout on voting day proves that the people of Arunachal Pradesh agree with him. While giving the Congress another term in office, the people of the tiny hilly state have also given Delhi an opportunity to debunk the shrill protests from Beijing.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

THE HUGE MAJORITY FOR THE CONGRESS SHOWS that voters ignored the anti-incumbency factor and gave a thumbs up to the development programmes.

ARUNACHAL PRADESH			Total Seats
			60
PARTIES	SEATS 2009	SEATS 2004	SEATS 1999
 Indian National Congress	42	36	53
 Bharatiya Janata Party	3	9	0
Independents and others	15	15	7

2004 Congress tally includes two from Arunachal Congress

2004. The large turnout, at a time when China is making belligerent noises about the state, is a telling statement by the people of Arunachal Pradesh that they are firmly with India.

Defection is so deeply rooted in the state's politics that the outgoing assembly did not even have a token opposition. Though the Congress had only 34 legislators, it was supported by 13 Independents and two from the Arunachal Congress, a regional